

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 2
Painting the Stars ~ Toward Healing the Rift
13 September 2026

LVF Update 7 September 6:30pm
COMMUNION

Welcoming New Members

Preaching: LVF
Worship Leading: ML and JPC

Organ Prelude-Concert

Improvisation on SLANE and BROTHER JAMES' AIR

Six movements from *Stabat Mater* by Giovanni Battista Pergolesi:

- Grave in F minor
- Andante amoroso in C minor
- Larghetto in G minor
- Largo in G minor
- Largo in F minor
- Allegro in G minor

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Michael center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Good morning and welcome to FCCLA! We give thanks for your presence here and your presence online, as we welcome all from near and far. We are a community that encourages and celebrates the fullness of who we are, a community where we are free to love whom we love, and where we are equipped to explore faith and spirituality at our own pace.

Today, we continue our fall series, *Painting the Stars*, as Rev. Laura guides us *Toward Healing the Rift*. Let us open our whole selves to the Sacred within and all around us as we share these Words of Gathering.

Words of Gathering

LVF & ML

[Michael from the front – LVF in the back]

ML: It is not as though
we stop and start our way through life,

jerking this way and that,
half yanking our feet from one course
and onto another.

LVF:: It is not as though we go so far and then,
consulting our maps,
make a sudden turn
and head off in a new direction.

ML: It is not as though
we choose each new beginning
from a menu of life's options.

LVF: And yet
each moment opens soft and pure
awaiting our response;
each day lifts its head from the dew-strung grasses
and offers new hope, new possibility, extra chances;
each idea stirs a constellation of thoughts into being
and we are captivated by their courses.

Both: *May we know and celebrate new beginnings
in our lives and the lives of others,
and, as we do,
may we honor what has passed
and hallow its traces
through our lives, our hearts, our loves.*

*To this we commit ourselves
as those who begin anew this day.*

ML: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn Of Gathering *The Sun is On the Sea and Shore* BROTHER JAMES' AIR**

■ The Sun is On the Sea and Shore - BROTHER JAMES' AIR.jpg

The sun is on the sea and shore, a new day has begun
With morning hymns we will adore the blessed Three-in-One;
And we shall praise you ever more, until the day is done.

Your love is ever in our view, like shining stars by night
Your gifts are every morning new, Oh God of love and light;
Your mercy, like the heavens blue, fills our dazzled sight.

We do not know what grief and care each coming day may bring;

The heart shall find some gladness there that trusts you in each thing;
The life that serves you everywhere will never cease to sing.

[Claire center chancel with FKF & Youth on floor]

***Children's Conversation & Prayer of Awareness**

CK

Holy One,
We pause and listen to the sound of silence in this place...

silence

We remember creation's beauty
the searing of shooting stars,
the colors of the planets in the night sky,
the space and power beyond our perceiving,
and with these memories, we are moved to prayer -
to praise the mystery of creation,
and to be grateful for the mystery of our life in this place.

May it ever be so.

May it ever be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen!

*Following this conversation, children are invited to join us for our Sunday morning programming. If you were unable to check your children in prior to the service, please accompany them to our Children's Welcome Table and check them in before returning to the service. Children must be picked up after worship before you head to Coffee Hour.

[All turn towards choir]

***Introit**

Ubi Caritas
Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*
Where Charity and Love are, God is there

Maurice Duruflé

[Jay to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

JPC

Let us now join our voices in this Lord's Prayer...

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.
We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.*

*We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.* [enfleshed]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

In the center of the whirlwind
lies an eye.
Still.
Open.
Calm.
Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries,
no storms,
only peace.

As we find our way in life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember that center
and, as the need arises,
and it must,
may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it as home.

[adptlvf/gvosper]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[Michael stays center chancel to invite new members forward, Christoph transition them up]

Welcoming New Members

ML

*Bobby Chun | Flower Chun | Dan Cox |
Alina Sunoo | Jack VanderGriend*

Let us join together in this litany of welcoming:

Beloved friends, we gather as one, woven together by the threads of love, justice, peace, and hope. Today, we are overjoyed to welcome these new members into our sacred community:
With open hearts and joyful spirits, we welcome you!

Each of you brings your unique story, faith, experience, insights, questions, enthusiasm, and gifts. Already, you are a blessing to all of us.

Together, we will welcome and celebrate your gifts, as we deepen our spiritual journeys, build community, and work for justice.

May you always find this community a place of belonging and acceptance, where you are known and cherished exactly as you are.

We promise to welcome and celebrate the fullness of who you are, and journey with you, celebrating your joys, and accompanying you in your struggles.

In the spirit of Christ's radical welcome, we say:

Welcome to the table of love. Welcome to the work of peace. Welcome to the church. You are home.

And now I ask our newest members of First Church: Will you commit to bring all that you are and all that hope to be in this community of faith? Sharing your unique gifts and talents for the strengthening of our community and in our service to our city and beyond? If so, please say, **We do! New Members: We do!**

Let us pray: God, we welcome these friends into community with us. We thank you for their presence and their willingness to join in the work of this congregation. Grant that we may be caring, supportive, prayerful, and intentional friends, working together for their good. Grant that they may find us a community of welcome and peace, a community of love, a community of intellectual rigor and thoughtfulness, a community of generosity. Together, we are the people of God in this place. Together, we will share God's love with our city, and our world. May it always be so, Amen!

Would you please join me in welcoming all our new members!

[Christoph transition after applause for new members to sign book and take seats, then Jay and Michael to center]

Readings from Our Tradition

JPC & ML

ML: Let us open our minds and hearts as we share these readings...

JPC: *from ‘On the Origin of Species’ by Charles Darwin, “Conclusion”*

It is interesting to contemplate a tangled bank, clothed with many plants of many kinds, with birds singing on the bushes, with various insects flitting about, and with worms crawling through the damp earth, and to reflect that these elaborately constructed forms, so different from each other, and dependent upon each other in so complex a manner, have all been produced by laws acting around us.

ML: These laws, taken in the largest sense, being
Growth with Reproduction;
Inheritance which is almost implied by reproduction;
Variability from the indirect and direct action of the conditions of life, and from use and disuse;
a Ratio of Increase so high as to lead to a Struggle for Life,
and as a consequence to Natural Selection,
entailing Divergence of Character and the
Extinction of less improved forms.

JPC: Thus, from the war of nature, from famine and death, the most exalted object which we are capable of conceiving, namely, the production of the higher animals, directly follows.

There is grandeur in this view of life, with its several powers, having been originally breathed by the Creator into a few forms or into one; and that, whilst this planet has gone cycling on according to the fixed law of gravity, from so simple a beginning endless forms most beautiful and most wonderful have been, and are being, evolved.

from the Gospel of John

from John 1

ML

ML: *And now, this reading from the Gospel of John, chapter 1.*

In the beginning was the Word;
the Word was in God’s presence,
and the Word was God.
The Word was present to God
from the beginning.

Through the Word
all things came into being,
and apart from the Word
nothing came into being.
In the Word was life,
and that life was humanity's light.

JPC: This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Jay to seat, Michael stay center chancel]

Prayers with the People

ML

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

The theologian Sallie McFague has said...
'In prayer a reversal occurs:
we do not talk about God and the world
but begin to see ourselves and the world *in* God.
We begin to see human life and the world
from the divine perspective,
from a broader and more inclusive point of view
than we are otherwise capable of holding.
We begin to recognize who we are in the scheme of things
from the perspective of the Creator and Redeemer of everything that is.
We are no longer the center [a definition of sin];
we now know God is the Center [a definition of salvation].

Word on the 25th Anniversary of 9.11

Let us now be in silence together...

[2 minutes of silence, then CB transition out of silence]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Let us join together in prayer:

Gathered in this place:
We acknowledge
a Power, a Presence
within us
within all people,
a creative, energizing Presence,
Divine,
bonding everything that exists
through patterns of attraction and co-operation,
in endless movement

toward new possibilities,
creating an interrelational universe
that makes human life possible.

***Conscious of this Divine presence
within and among us,
we open ourselves to new possibilities.***

We expand our minds,
we embrace change,
we take risks,
we discard what no longer gives meaning to life,
we deepen our awareness and appreciation
of this Presence
emerging in us.

***On this day, we give thanks for the wonderful human gift
of conscious awareness.***

We give thanks, that in us,
the universe has found a way to reflect upon itself,
to sing, to dance,
to celebrate the joy of sound and movement,
to consciously love,
to be enthralled by the creation of new life
and new possibilities.

We open ourselves to the challenge
of fully co-operating with the energizing, creative,
Divine Presence in our own personal development,
in our relationships with all other people
and in our connectedness with and **care for planet Earth.**

***To all that is,
and to all that could be
through the power of the Presence
within all things,
we say, Amen.*** [mmoorwood]

[Christoph transition for Choir]

Meditation Anthem There is a Balm in Gilead Traditional African-American Spiritual
Tiffany Ho, *Soloist*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor* Arr. William Dawson

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon

Toward Healing the Rift

LVF

[Christoph transition as Michael & Jay go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings

ML & JPC

JPC: We give thanks, Great Transformer.
You are the power that turns helium and hydrogen
into starfields,
and exploding stars into building blocks of life.
You are the intelligence that, through deep time,
turns lava into llamas,
and bacteria into Beethoven's symphonies.

ML: At the Cana wedding,
Jesus turned water into wine,
the miracle being not the transformation
(for this is your signature),
but the time it took –
the wink of a mother's eye.

JPC: And so this morning as we gather at this table,
we know, Holy One, that in your hands,
we too may be transformed, and learn again
that you have saved the best in us for last.

ML (Jay breaks the bread): We take this bread as Jesus took it,
we break it and we bless it,
knowing that this bread of new life
is one of the building blocks
of the life we share.

JPC (Michael pours the cup): We take this cup as Jesus did,
we pour it and we bless it,
remembering that the miracles
of transformation begin
with this cup of hope
we share.

Prayer of Blessing

JPC: Holy One,
we come to this table,
incarnating in our blood and bones,
in chemistry and consciousness,
this shape-shifting universe.

As we receive this bread and this cup –
symbols of self-giving love,
we remember Jesus and his life, death,

and life from death, that continues
to evolve in each of our lives.
We pray this with the Spirit of Life
that flowed through Jesus
and now flows through our bodies
and into this world.
Amen and Amen.

Words of Invitation

ML: You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith, or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[Jay to lectern when all have been served and music stops]

Invitation to Generosity

Jay

In the rising of the sun and its setting,
in the glow of the moon and its seasons,
in the infinity of space and its shining stars,
we experience God with gratitude.

This morning, we remember
the harmony of heaven in the relationships of earth,
and respond to the expanse of this mystery
within ourselves and each other.

Our offerings and gifts are an essential part of this remembrance.
We give thanks to God for this life we are privileged to share,
and we give from our resources to ensure that this congregation -
continues to grow in its commitment to being a place where all God's children
are celebrated and loved, and where people are fed in mind, body, heart, and spirit.

You will find information for online giving in your programs and appearing now on your screens at home. Our Hospitality Team will also come forward to receive your gifts.

Offertory

The Peace of Wild Things Michael Conley, Text: Wendell Berry
Laude, Rohan Ramanan, *Oboe*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your praise shall sound from shore to shore

till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Jay to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

JPC

Let us pray:

Holy One,

we give thanks for the people gathered
around us today.

We give thanks for the things of the earth
that support and sustain us
and make life abundant.

Help us, O God, to see our place
among these gifts.

May we not squander them
or use them for selfish gains.

Instead help us to respect the life
of all you have made.

*May our spirits now be strengthened
by the sharing of our gifts and resources
and may we use all that we have,
and all that we are,
to help those who need us.*

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen!

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

ML & LVF

ML: Recognition of Meg Coulter's 75-year church membership anniversary & 88th Bday

LVF:

Words of Blessing

LVF

Let us share this Gaelic blessing that comes
to us from our ancestors long ago:

Deep peace of the running wave to you...

Deep peace of the flowing air to you...

Deep peace of the quiet earth to you...

Deep peace of the shining stars to you...

Deep peace of the One who is peace to you...

both this day and in all the days to come.

Amen and Amen!

[adapt/gaelicblessing]

Choral Response

A Gaelic Blessing

John Rutter

Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*; Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn for the Journey**

Wake Now My Senses

SLANE

In the drive with descant -

Wake now my senses, and hear the Earth call,
feel the deep power of being in all,
keep with the web of creation your vow,
giving receiving, as love shows us how.

Wake now my reason, reach out for the new,
join with each trav'ler who quests for the true,
honor the beauty and wisdom of time,
transcend our limits and touch the sublime.

Wake now my vision, the dream we hold dear,
brighten our pathway with radiance here,
journey together with all who will share,
love for the planet transformed by our care.

--lyrics Mikelson

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Amen (Giovanni Battista Pergolesi)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music -Dr. Ianthe Marini

Each musical element of our service today explores some aspect *towards healing the rift*. In Maurice Duruflé's *Ubi Caritas*, he sets the famous 8th-century chant melody, which in itself is a musical setting of the ancient text *Ubi Caritas et amor, Deus ibi est—where charity and love are,*

God is there. Historians of chant surmise that this text has been sung since the 4th century and is a musical rendering of the 1st century verse in 1 John 4:8 which explores The Divine as *Love* itself. In Duruflé's setting, the choir alternates between communal chant and homophonic strophic hymn singing—a representation that love and charity and the exploration of The Divine as both takes form both individually and collectively. There is a magic in singing an idea from the 1st century which took form as a poem in the 4th and later a chant in the 8th, to a choral piece in the 1960s sung in our space today in 2026. We are interconnected through the ancestral breath of *LOVE*, and it is from there that we sing.

William Dawson's setting of the 19th century African-American Spiritual *There is a Balm in Gilead* is an expression of healing as resilience through faith. *Is there no balm in Gilead?*—cries the prophet in Jeremiah 8:22 amidst great spiritual and social unrest of the time. This cry translates to the prayer of the enslaved in our own country that *yes—there IS a Balm to heal the sin-sick soul*. “*Sin*” here is used to describe that which separates us from the Divine: cruelty, injustice, enslavement.

At the offertory, we hear the poetic rendering of words by the late Wendell Berry, environmental activist, farmer, and inspiration, friend, and guide to our work here at First Church. “*When despair for the world grows in me, I go and lie down where the wood drake rests in his beauty on the water and the great heron feeds. I come into the peace of wild things who do not tax their lives with forethought of grief. For a time I rest in the grace of the world and am free*”, he writes in his own poetic understanding of *healing the rift*. And finally, we sing John Rutter's setting of The Gaelic Blessing which we have spoken together many times: words that come to us from the ancestors of the Celtic tradition, exploring our inherent goodness and our interconnectivity with the sacred Earth. *Deep Peace of the running wave, the quiet earth, the shining stars to you.*